CULURGIONES ALLA NUORESE

REGION	SERVES	TOTAL TIME
South	**4-6**	**1 h 30 min plus the dough rest**

INGREDIENTS

456 g	Yukon gold potatoes
232 g	Ricotta
22 g	Pecorino romano, finely grated
30 g	Fiore sardo, finely grated, for the filling
quantity not given	Salt
1 batch	Semolina dough
750 g	Simple red sauce
22 g	Fiore sardo, finely grated, to finish
quantity not given	Mint leaves, for garnish

METHOD

1. Cover the potatoes with cold water in a pot and set them over medium heat to come to a gentle simmer. Give them 30 to 45 minutes, until a fork slides through easily.
2. Lift them out with a slotted spoon onto a sheet pan and leave them about 15 minutes. They cool and dry out a little at the same time.
3. Once you can handle them, peel the potatoes and pass them through a ricer or food mill into a bowl.
4. Set a tamis or fine-mesh strainer over that same bowl and push the ricotta through it. Fold in the pecorino and the 30 g fiore sardo until evenly worked through. Salt until it tastes well seasoned on its own. Cover and refrigerate until you need it.
5. Make 32 culurgiones from the semolina dough and the filling.
6. Salt a large pot of water generously and bring it to the boil.
7. Warm the red sauce in a small sauce pot over low heat.
8. Cook the culurgiones 3 to 5 minutes, until tender at the thickest point of the closure.
9. While they cook, ladle 125 g of sauce into the base of each plate or shallow bowl.
10. Lift the pasta out with a spider or slotted spoon and divide it between the plates. Finish with the remaining fiore sardo and the mint leaves.

NOTES

Mint stays out of the filling and goes on raw at the end. Cooking it shifts the flavor and dulls its impact.
Fiore sardo works twice: smoky cheese inside the filling, and a very fine grating of it over the finished dish.
Judge doneness at the thick seam where the pasta is folded shut, not on the flat of the parcel. That closure is the last part to come good.
In Nuoro the filling is potato with aged pecorino, mint and sheep's milk ricotta, and the parcels come in a simple tomato sauce. Elsewhere on Sardinia the same parcels turn up in brown butter with walnuts and pistachios, or with orange zest and guanciale, or deep-fried, or pan-seared.

FILLING

Potato, Ricotta, and Fiore Sardo Filling

INGREDIENTS

456 g	Yukon gold potatoes
232 g	Ricotta
22 g	Pecorino romano, finely grated
30 g	Fiore sardo, finely grated
quantity not given	Salt

METHOD

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4. Set a tamis or fine-mesh strainer over that same bowl and push the ricotta through it.
5. Fold in the pecorino and fiore sardo until evenly worked through, then salt until it tastes well seasoned on its own.
6. Cover and refrigerate until you are ready to fill.

NOTES

Boiling the potatoes whole and resting them 15 minutes before ricing drives off moisture, which keeps the filling from going slack.
Push the ricotta through a tamis rather than stirring it in. That takes the grain out of it so the filling stays smooth against the riced potato.
Season it until it tastes well seasoned by itself. It is diluted by the pasta and the sauce around it.
Fiore sardo is the smoky note. Pecorino romano carries the salt and sharpness.
No mint in the filling. Cooked mint loses its edge, so mint belongs on the plate instead.

SAUCE

Simple Red Sauce

Makes: 2.25 kg / Active Time: 30 min / Total Time: 30 min

INGREDIENTS

75 g	Extra-virgin olive oil
40 g	Garlic, thinly sliced
quantity not given	Dried red chile flakes
2382 g	Whole San Marzano tomatoes, crushed by hand, from three 794 g cans
quantity not given	Salt

METHOD

1. Put a Dutch oven, or any heavy pot of that size, on a low flame. In go the oil and the garlic, gently, for 30 seconds to a minute, until the smell comes up but before any colour does. Add chile flakes to taste.
2. Tip in the tomatoes with all their juice and hold it on low for 25 to 30 minutes. You are not reducing it, only letting the flavours come together. Salt to taste.
3. Take it off the heat and use it, or cool it and store it.

NOTES

The brief here is thirty minutes and a short shopping list, with nothing dominating. It should work on rigatoni, inside a lasagna, and ladled into a braise.
Do not let the garlic colour. The whole character of the sauce turns if it browns.
Resist reducing it. Twenty-five to thirty minutes on low is about blending, not thickening.
This is the one to settle your preferred tomato brand, house olive oil and garlic level on, so treat the quantities as a starting point.
Vegan as written.
Used by the eggplant mezzelune.

SHAPE

Culurgiones

Region: Sardinia, with the braided teardrop form centered on the mountainous east near Nuoro / Rest: 45 minutes to 1 hour uncovered in the refrigerator

METHOD

1. Make the semolina dough, then roll and sheet it.
2. Dust a wooden board with 00 flour. Cover a sheet pan with parchment, then dust the parchment with semolina.
3. Lay one sheet on the board. Cut rounds with a #90 (3 1/2-inch) fluted pastry cutter, leaving 1/8 inch between them.
4. Spoon about 16 g of filling into the center of each round.
5. If the dough feels dry rather than tacky, mist the rounds with a spray bottle held 8 to 10 inches above the board. Skip this if the dough is already tacky.
6. Cup a round in your palm and bring the sides up with your other hand so it takes a taco-like form.
7. Starting at one end, use your index finger to fold that end of the circle in over the filling.
8. With your middle finger and thumb, squeeze the two sides of dough closed over that folded end into a triangular closure, then push the top of the closure down into the filling with your index finger. Keep repeating the fold and pinch down the length of the seam to build a fishtail braid, and pinch the far end closed into a small tail.
9. Set the piece on the prepared pan. Fill and braid the rest of the rounds, keeping them in a single layer, and dust the pan again with semolina.
10. Repeat with the remaining sheets.
11. Refrigerate uncovered for 45 minutes to 1 hour to dry. Covered pieces sweat and get too wet. To hold longer, lay plastic wrap loosely over the pan and refrigerate up to 8 hours.

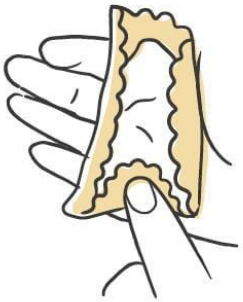
SHAPING



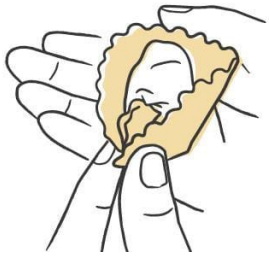
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2



3



4



5



6

NOTES

Cut from 3 1/2-inch rounds (#90 fluted cutter), spaced 1/8 inch apart. That is the largest round called for among these shapes.
Filling per piece: about 16 g, spooned rather than piped. This is the only shape in the group with the filling given as a weight.
Seal geometry: no fold-and-pinch edge. The round is cupped into a taco, one end is folded in over the filling, and then alternating pinches up the seam build a fishtail braid that finishes in a small pinched tail.
Needs the semolina dough, not an egg dough.
The sheets and the filling both soften as they sit out. Keep them in the refrigerator and pull them in batches.
Storage: 45 minutes to 1 hour uncovered to dry, then up to 8 hours refrigerated under loose plastic.
Filling is usually greens or fresh herbs with potato and both fresh and aged pecorino sardo.
Served in a simple tomato sauce, finished with mint and fiore sardo.

DOUGH

Semolina Dough

Makes: 750 g / Active Time: 10-15 min kneading / Rest: 30 min minimum, wrapped

INGREDIENTS

325 g	Tipo 00 flour
175 g	Semolina flour
250 g	Lukewarm water
up to 1 tbsp, only if dry	Room-temperature water

METHOD

1. Stir the two flours together thoroughly, then mound on a wooden surface with a well 5 to 6 inches across.
2. Add the water slowly. Water has no body of its own, so it escapes far more easily than yolks do.
3. Draw in flour from the inner wall with a fork as you pour, working round the circumference until all the water is in.
4. Knead 10 to 15 minutes, pressing down and away, rotating, folding.
5. Add water by the tablespoon only if it stays dry.
6. Wrap and rest at least 30 minutes.

NOTES

Eggless, so it stays more elastic and less tender than egg dough. Do not expect the Play-Doh feel here.
50% hydration against 500 g total flour.
65% of the flour is 00 and 35% semolina.
Keeps 24 hours. Chilled overnight, pull it out 20 minutes before rolling.